Looking out the window, I need only think of what I regret in life
for plum blossoms to fall and cover South Mountain.

A few months ago, I read Zhang Zao's "In the Mirror." It has stayed with me ever since, simply because I sensed a beauty in it that I could not quite explain. There are many other scraps of modern poetry like this: "The bright moon adorns your window; you adorn someone else's dream," from Bian Zhilin's "Fragment"; "Guanyin is on a mountain far away; poppies are in the poppy fields," from Ya Hsien's "Andante Cantabile."

One rainy night, I walked across the Shuangjie River Bridge in Qianhai. As I listened to music, the whole city floated inside me, and I felt like an albatross crossing the sea. It was a night complete in itself. Each dark square in the apartment towers held someone with a life as full and complex as my own. For a moment, the world astonished me. We are each an albatross flying alone over a sea of people. Yet we are also stretches of ocean, large or small, beneath someone else's flight, with ripples that have traveled near or far. The world is mine, so the immense moon shines only on the window I look toward, mocking all the places I cannot see. The world belongs to others too, so my gaze passes through that window into someone else's story and becomes part of it. And so, that night, I remembered Bian Zhilin's "Fragment."

These occasional entanglements of life and poetry always move me. They tend not to happen while I am reading, or while I am stubbornly searching for an answer. They happen in subtle moments like this, when a poem offers a clear and precious gloss on a feeling I can barely make out.

Room 2309 is behind us now. A year later, I have left that building for 5211: the same arrangement, the same people, all of us together again in Mr. Crow's class. This is our third year.

The city's rainy season comes in summer. Outside the floor-to-ceiling windows of 5211, the banyans and palms stand in the rain all day. This time next year, I will no longer be sitting here watching the trees in the rain, or listening to Mr. Crow. I will become one of the countless young people they have seen off, and not a particularly remarkable one. Before the next rainy season comes, I suppose I will have to find somewhere else to take shelter. Insects and frogs might only need to find a pothos leaf and hold it over their heads—at least, that was how the comic books I read as a child pictured it. People, it seems, need a concrete house, a comfortable income, and a respectable car to get through the rainy season. If keeping out the rain were all we needed, an umbrella would do. The trouble is, there are other things to fend off or satisfy: other people's endless refrains and our own cravings, in all their forms. Well, I hope I can make my way through the rain, the refrains, the cravings with just an umbrella. "Bamboo staff and straw sandals, lighter than riding; a straw cape, and a lifetime of mist and rain."

The reason I started writing this, actually, was that Mr. Crow had asked us to write something. He wanted us to recall events that had deeply affected us. My mind wandered around the room for a long time. It had no idea what to write. I did take the opportunity to remember all sorts of things. Most of them I did not know how to write about. Mr. Crow was not asking us to turn anything in, and he would not give us a hard time about it. Still, whether to finish the assignment or simply pass the time, I thought I really ought to remember something now, and then write it down.

The things that leave their mark on us seem so often to be things we regret. At least, sitting in classroom 5211, I mostly remembered things I regretted. Perhaps regret is simply a feeling both deep and ordinary. Mr. Crow wanted us to face these things. He was not going to collect our writing, and no one would leaf through it anyway; putting it all down seemed a decent way to let it out. I did remember things—six or seven thoughts beginning "I shouldn't have." But I wrote none of them down. I only stole a little time to draft the words above, then went back to watching the rain beat against the palm leaves.

"Rain beats on pear blossoms; the door is shut tight. Youth forgotten, youth misspent." These are lines the poet Tang Bohu left us. The rain keeps beating on the palms outside the windows, and youth really is slipping away, as quietly as the water gathering along the middle of a palm leaf and running off. Many doors have closed for good. Some needed to close, I think; others I wish had not. Perhaps this feeling comes close to what Tang Bohu wrote of as youth misspent. Well, perhaps he had something entirely different in mind, and I cannot really relate. His youth was supposedly quite glorious. I have never had that kind of glory.

I look toward the window. My thoughts are the unending summer rains on Mount Wutong. Rain falls on banyan roots, on palm leaves, on the two campuses at opposite ends of the city where I have spent the past six years. It falls on the Shuangjie River beneath the bridge at night, and soaks an exam paper I never want to see again. At last, the summer rain washes all of Mount Wutong away.

As "Fragment" once did, the closing lines of "In the Mirror" finally catch hold of me:

Looking out the window, I need only think of what I regret in life
for plum blossoms to fall and cover South Mountain.

I feel as though I have only just reached the beginning of my life. Perhaps the rain—or the plum blossoms—in my memory will only fall harder in the days to come.

The days wrap around me like plum petals, one by one, until I become plum blossoms myself, falling to cover your South Mountain.